

Inside the AI technology behind the 2026 FIFA World Cup

From tactical analysis to AI-generated player avatars, here's how **technology is reshaping** every aspect of the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

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For 90 minutes, Cape Verde frustrated Spain. One of the tournament favourites monopolised possession, unleashed 27 shots and spent much of the afternoon camped around its opponent's penalty area. But when the final whistle arrived at the Mercedes-Benz Stadium, the scoreboard still read 0-0.

It was one of the early surprises of the 2026 FIFA World Cup and, in many ways, the perfect rebuttal to critics who feared the expanded 48-team tournament would produce more one-sided group-stage mismatches.

Behind the goals, packed stadiums and global television audiences, this World Cup has become an unprecedented technology experiment. **From AI-powered tactical analysis and digital player avatars to an intelligent command centre connecting operations across North America, football's governing body and technology partner Lenovo are leveraging artificial intelligence to transform how the game is played, managed, and experienced.**

"This is the first ever largest event on the globe that is so technologically powered," Asia Sheikh, the Global CTO, Sports & Entertainment

Innovation, Lenovo, told *Sportstar*. "This is the first AI-native sporting event of its kind."

At the heart of that vision is FIFA AI Pro, a platform developed jointly by FIFA and Lenovo that provides all 48 participating nations with access to advanced tactical analysis.

Historically, football's richest teams and federations have enjoyed significant advantages through larger coaching staffs, proprietary data systems and teams of analysts. FIFA AI Pro aims to narrow that gap by turning vast amounts of football data into tactical reports, video breakdowns and visual insights available to every team. The system draws on millions of FIFA-owned data points and thousands of football-specific metrics, helping coaches identify patterns, tendencies and potential tactical adjustments.

For FIFA, the objective extends beyond simply creating a better analytics tool.

"We are ensuring that innovation benefits every player, every team, and every fan everywhere in the world and, of course, benefits the greatest game of all, football," FIFA president Gianni Infantino had said while introducing the initiative.

For the first time, analysts from Cape Verde can access the same tactical insights available to Spain. Iraq can prepare for France using the same analytical framework employed by